Chapter 6

The Wake-up Call from the Upanishads

In Search of a Human

People in ancient Corinth got amused by seeing him. In full daylight, he was strolling through the streets with a lamp, as if he were searching for something in pitch darkness. He was the great Greek philosopher, Diogenes. When people asked what he was searching for, he answered forthwith, "I am looking for a human." In a street crowded with hundreds of people, he is still searching for a "human". Another renowned Greek philosopher, Sophocles, says, "Wonders are many, and none is more wonderful than man." Have you ever wondered, what makes human beings special? Sophocles continues, "The power that crosses the white sea, driven by stormy wind, making a path under surges that threaten to engulf him." He is right; even though we don't have the physical ability to run like a cheetah, attack like an elephant, see like an eagle, or sniff like a dog, we still survive and transcend many limitations and challenges from nature.

Observe the accomplishments of mankind. They not only crossed the mighty oceans, but they even touched the moon. As an artist designs an art, scientists manage to design and edit human DNA. With their brilliant intelligence, they even started to make intelligence itself. They increased their quality of life and lifespan. However, if we look into them carefully, all these are nothing but their efforts to minimise sorrow and maximise happiness. That is common for all living beings. Moreover, we find that these advancements often complicate and even threaten the very existence of life. In his famous work, Acharya Chanakya says:

> Humans have eating, sleeping, fearing, and mating in common with animals. That in which men excel the beasts is discretionary knowledge; Hence, indiscreet men who are without knowledge should be regarded as beasts[1].

According to him, knowledge is the one thing that distinguishes humans from other animals. That knowledge is not ordinary knowledge that is only useful for living. Because even animals have the knowledge and necessary skills to get their food, make nests to safely live in, protect themselves from predators, attract their mates, and raise their children. Then what would be that knowledge that distinguishes humans from animals?

Conversation with Death

There is a beautiful story in the Katha Upanishad. A boy named Nachiketa went to the world of death. The god of death offered three boons for the boy[2]. The third boon he requested was actually a doubt. He asked for knowledge about death and life. Yama was reluctant to answer; He said that this knowledge is very

[1] "आहारनिद्राभयमैथुनानि समानि चैतानि नृणां पशूनाम् । ज्ञानं नराणामधिको विशेषो ज्ञानेन हीनाः पशुभिः समानाः॥", *Chapter 17, Chanakya Neeti*

[2] *The first boon was to pacify his father's anger towards Nachiketa, the second boon was knowledge about a sacred Yajna.*

subtle, and requested that Nachiketa ask something else. Yama offered him many precious worldly things; however, the boy, with strong determination, politely rejected all those gifts, and humbly requested that Yama clear his doubt. After many rounds of discussion, Yama was finally convinced by the boy's strong dedication and determination. He revealed the secret of death and life. The Upanishads say that eligibility for that supreme knowledge alone distinguishes human beings from animals, and that is the cheat code to crack the snake and ladder game of life and death.

Upanishads are part of the Vedas, and they discuss this supreme knowledge. Even though they are considered sacred literature, they are different from other religious scriptures. While religious texts are filled with matters related to God, praises to God, detailed descriptions of heaven and hell, and dos and don'ts, the focus of the Upanishad is more on the supreme knowledge that frees humans from the limitations and bondages of the world. While all other knowledge is about the objects that we perceive through either our sense organs or our mind, the supreme knowledge of the Upanishads is interested not in the objects that we perceive but in the perceiver itself. While answering Nachiketa, Yama is saying that:

> The knowing Self is not born; It does not die. It has not sprung from anything; nothing has sprung from It. Birthless, eternal, everlasting and ancient, It is not killed when the body is killed.
>
> Katha Upanishad 1.2.18[3]

This is the true nature of the self—Atman. It is not limited to the body, mind, birth, death, happiness, and sorrow.

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[3] न जायते म्रियते वा विपश्चिन् नायं कुतश्चिन्न बभूव कश्चित् । अजो नित्यः शाश्वतोऽयं पुराणो न हन्यते हन्यमाने शरीरे ॥ कठ उपनिषद् 1.2.18

Knowing the 'I'

We are always curious about the things we perceive. However, have you ever thought about the perceiver—the 'I'? All our actions are pivoted on this 'I', in all our conversations we repeat this word like a mantra, yet we are less informed about that very 'I'. You may know a thousand things about the world that you see with your eyes, but do you know the phenomenon that experiences the vision? Maybe you can describe the physical and cognitive processes of vision. But who is experiencing all these? What is that fundamental subjective experience?

There is a fascinating story. Once King Janaka had a bewildering dream. In his dream, he found himself as a destitute beggar, pleading for scraps and eventually collapsing from hunger on the streets. Suddenly he woke up from the dream. As he opened his eyes, the street and burning sun had vanished. He looked at his own body. He was not covered in tattered rags anymore. He was richly adorned with precious gems and dazzling stones that glistened like stars in the night sky. He was inside his luxurious palace, surrounded by servants attending to his every need.

This experience baffled him, and raised a question in his mind, "Am I the king who dreamt that he was a beggar? Or am I the beggar who is dreaming that he is a king? Which is my real identity?" He wanted an answer. So he sought his Guru.

The Guru revealed that Janaka was neither the humble beggar of his dreams nor an illustrious king, as he finds himself now. He is not even the unconscious one in the state of deep sleep. Reality is that he / she is the experiencer (the 'I'), unaffected by the experiences that come during sleep, dream or waking states.

That 'I' is not any of the objects we perceive because I am distinct from the objects that I perceive. Similarly, I am not any of the

sense organs, since I can perceive them also. How can I be the mind, different emotions, intellect, or thoughts? Because I can perceive them too! The Upanishads teach us that 'I' or Self is the 'witness'. It is free from all dyads like pleasure and pain, happiness and sorrow, and desire and distress.

The Real Nature

It is reasonable to doubt the existence of things like God(s), hell, heaven, angels, etc. that are beyond our sensory experience. One can even doubt the existence of objects that are empirically experienceable. For example, in deserts, we may see an oasis with our eyes, but when we reach closer, we realise there is no oasis; it was a mirage. Sometimes we may even doubt the existence of our own body. However, irrespective of the situation, nobody can doubt the existence of the 'I'. Because existence is the very nature of the self, it is called 'Sat'.

This 'I' consciousness forms the basis of all sensory perception and knowledge acquisition. Knowledge, or cognition, is possible only if there is a perceiver to perceive and comprehend. This consciousness is the light that illuminates everything. We can know about things outside of us through our sense organs. Things in the dream and mind we can know through the mind itself. However, without the mind or sensory organs, we are still able to know the presence of that subjective experience. We know because it is self-luminous. This consciousness is the nature of the 'I', it is the base of all other knowledge. It is called 'Chit'.

In the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad, King Janaka asks Sage Yajnavalkya, "What is the light that illuminates a person, the light that awakens and impels him to perform all that he does?" "Sun", the Sage replied. But the King again asked, "What helps a person in the absence of the sun at night?" "Moon", Yajnavalkya replied. "What is the light in the absence of both the sun and

the moon?"Janaka raised another question. "Fire is the light for us in the absence of the sun and moon", the Sage answered. The king did not stop there, "What is the light in the absence of the sun, moon and fire". "Voice is the light in the absence of other lights. We use voice and move forward in the absence of light", the Sage replied. "What is the light in the absence of sun, moon, fire and voice?", he wondered again. The Sage replied, "Even in the absence of the sun, moon, fire and voice, we have a light, that is the Self."

After listening to this answer, Janaka got the clarity that the self is the light of lights, which illuminates even the fire, moon and sun. In a dark room, when we switch on the light, everything is revealed by that light— tables, chairs, beds, everything in that room is revealed by that light. But to see that light we don't need any other light. Because that light is visible by its own light. Similarly, consciousness is the very nature of Self. Self is consciousness. All the experiences, thoughts, and physical world are based on consciousness. Just like we are watching a movie on screen, everything appears on the screen of consciousness.

In the absence of emotions, thoughts, and external objects, what is our experience? For example, in deep sleep, we are completely separated from things that bring happiness or sorrow. There are no thoughts or dreams in the mind to indulge in. Without internal and external things, we experience absolute peace, or bliss. Irrespective of external situations, whether you are a millionaire or a beggar, in deep sleep you experience bliss. Bliss, or Ananda, is the nature of the 'I'.

The Upanishads teach us that, Sat-Chit-Ananda (Existence, consciousness, and bliss) is the real nature of the individual self. They also proclaim that the world that we perceive has a relative existence; the base of the ever changing world is the changeless supreme self. Even though different

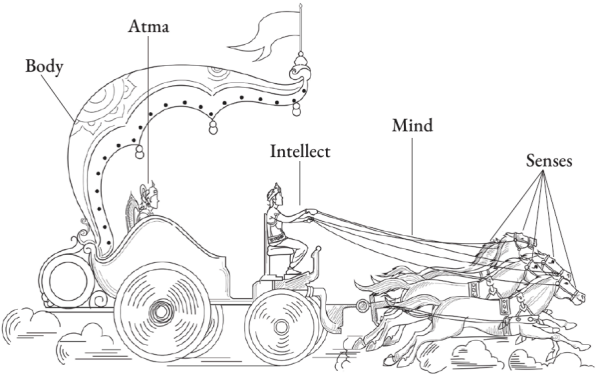
ornaments have relative existence, in reality they are just the same gold. Similarly, the world that we experience is the non-dual supreme self in ultimate reality. According to the Upanishads, when we realise this non-dual nature of reality, we transcend all delusions and grief. This potential for realising this knowledge, makes human beings distinct from animals.

Ignorance to Awareness

In our worldly circumstances, we experience suffering and grief, but upanishads say our true nature is Ananda; how could that be possible? The Upanishads point towards ignorance, where we wrongly perceive ourselves as a combination of mind, body, and intellect. As one thinks the moon is distorted, by seeing the reflection of the moon in moving water, we are wrongly identifying ourselves with body, mind, and intellect. In fact, as the moon is not affected by the distortion of its reflection, so is the self unaffected by different states of the body, and emotions, and thoughts of the mind.

Yama illustrates this idea through the brilliant analogy of a chariot.

He says the senses are the horses, and they run through different roads that are the objects. The Body is the chariot and intellect



is the charioteer who controls the sense–horses with the reins of mind. Atman, or the self, is the master of the chariot and unaffected by mind, body, and intellect[4].

> **Activity:** Reflect on the chariot metaphor from the Katha Upanishad: Why are senses compared to horses, objects to roads, body to the chariot, and intellect to the charioteer? Why is Atman, the self, depicted as the master of the chariot, unaffected by mind, body, and intellect?

According to the Upanishads, we are not sinners or slaves, but we are the children of immortality. Shvetashvatara Upanishad glorifies us as "Listen, O the children of immortality the world over"[5]. All of us are potentially divine. They call on us to remove the wrong identification, and realise our true nature, which is free from all grief and delusion.

Amma says, "We are not candles to be lit by somebody else. We are the self-effulgent sun."

Upanishads ask us to be strong by shedding down false identifications and weaknesses. According to them, that should be the ultimate aim of all spiritual and religious practices. They proclaim eternal independence from all the bonds. To realise this ultimate knowledge, the Lord of Death suggests a practical method,

Uttishtata jagrata prapya varannibodhata

Arise! Awake! Approach the great and learn[6]

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[4] Katha Upanishad 1.3.4

[5] शृण्वन्तु विश्वे अमृतस्य पुत्रा (śṛṇvantu viśve amṛtasya putrā), Shvetashvatara Upanishad 2.5

[6] Katha Upanishad 1.3.14

"The Upanishads are the great mine of strength. Therein lies strength enough to invigorate the whole world; the whole world can be vivified, made strong, energised through them. They will call with trumpet voice upon the weak, the miserable, and the downtrodden of all races, all creeds, and all sects to stand on their feet and be free. Freedom, physical freedom, mental freedom, and spiritual freedom are the watchwords of the Upanishads."

Swami Vivekananda (Lectures from Colombo to Almora-Vedanta in its Application to Indian Life)